

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 1/12: Central question and the five-layer answer

CENTRAL QUESTION -> why does India join so many overlapping groupings?

ANSWER -> each layer buys a different, non-identical interest

LAYER 1 REGIONAL -> SAARC | BIMSTEC | Mekong-Ganga Cooperation

LAYER 2 TRANS-REGIONAL -> IORA | IBSA

LAYER 3 CONTINENTAL -> Shanghai Cooperation Organisation

LAYER 4 GLOBAL GOVERNANCE -> Group of Twenty | BRICS

LAYER 5 MINILATERAL -> Quad | Russia-India-China | I2U2

RULE -> name the layer before analysing the body

BOUNDARY -> Quad maritime security to topic 04; SCO connectivity to topic 05;

Global South to topic 08; UN and Bretton Woods reform linkage to topic 12

MUST REMEMBER: Regional, global and minilateral groupings vary by treaty basis,...

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 2/12: South Asian layer read as a dated record

26-27 NOVEMBER 2014 -> 18th SAARC Summit at Kathmandu, the last Summit held

STATUS -> charter-based body, 8 members plus observers, still in existence

8 FEBRUARY 2004 -> BIMSTEC free trade area framework agreement; no FTA concluded

30 MARCH 2022 -> BIMSTEC Charter adopted at Colombo

20 MAY 2024 -> BIMSTEC Charter enters into force; 7 members

4 APRIL 2025 -> 6th BIMSTEC Summit, Bangkok; Bangladesh takes the chair

adopts Summit Declaration, Bangkok Vision 2030, Rules of Procedure,

Eminent Persons Group report; endorses the 28 March 2025 earthquake statement

RULE -> renamed BIMST-EC and BIMSTEC are one lineage, not two organisations

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 3/12: Where regional integration actually slows

PROBLEM -> summit outputs are read as regional obligations

RESPONSE: a declaration, a vision document, rules of procedure and an expert report are four evidentiary levels and none is a treaty obligation

PROBLEM -> an agreement in force is read as binding the whole region

RESPONSE: BIMSTEC Agreement on Maritime Transport Cooperation signed 3 April 2025; in force 16 May 2026 among Bhutan, India, Myanmar, Thailand after Myanmar deposited the fourth instrument on 13 May 2026

DIAGNOSIS -> variable-geometry ratification, not summit reluctance

RULE -> in force for four of seven is the answer-grabbing formulation

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 4/12: Participation tiers and what each one confers

SAARC	-> 8 members	observers
BIMSTEC	-> 7 members	no separate tier recorded
ASEAN	-> 11 members	dialogue partners; India full since 1995
Timor-Leste admitted at the 47th ASEAN Summit, 26 October 2025		
IORA	-> 23 member states	12 dialogue partners
SCO	-> 10 members	2 observers, 15 dialogue partners
BRICS	-> 11 full members	10 partner countries, from 24 Oct 2024
G20	-> 19 states + EU + AU	guests and invited organisations
QUAD	-> 4 participants	non-treaty consultative minilateral
RULE -> tiers expand reach without expanding decision rights		

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 5/12: Southeast Asian architecture and the trade-agreement map

22nd ASEAN-INDIA SUMMIT -> Kuala Lumpur, 26 October 2025

FRAMEWORK -> ASEAN-India Plan of Action for the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership, 2026-2030

AITIGA REVIEW -> ongoing, expressly not concluded

ASEAN FTA PARTNERS -> China | South Korea | Japan | India |
Australia-New Zealand | Hong Kong

RCEP -> ASEAN with Australia, China, Japan, South Korea, New Zealand

INDIA IN RCEP -> not a member

TRAP -> an ASEAN dialogue or trade partner is not thereby an ASEAN member

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 6/12: Oceanic and continental layers with their dated outcomes

IORA -> Indian Ocean Rim Association, earlier IOR-ARC

Secretariat at Ebene, Mauritius; India chairs 2025-27, assumed November 2025

24th Council of Ministers met virtually 21 May 2025; Colombo Communique

cited by Tharoor as a platform engaged alongside larger bodies

SCO -> charter-based Eurasian intergovernmental organisation

India a full member since 2017; China, Russia, Pakistan, Iran, Belarus inside

Tianjin summit 31 August-1 September 2025; Tianjin Declaration

Kyrgyzstan chairs 2025-26

LIMIT -> a seat supplies voice, never privileged access or shared threat views

CLOSE DISTINCTION: Member, observer, dialogue partner, guest, chair and invited...

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 7/12: Global-governance layer counted correctly

BRICS -> 11 full members; not a treaty alliance

partner-country category of 10 created through the Kazan process, 24 Oct 2024

17th Summit, Rio de Janeiro, 6-7 July 2025 -> Rio de Janeiro Declaration

India chairship 2026 launched 13 January 2026 with theme, logo and website

no 2026 Leaders' Summit outcome officially verified as of 3 August 2026

NEW DEVELOPMENT BANK -> 10 actual members

five founders + Bangladesh 2021, UAE 2021, Egypt 2023, Algeria 2025,

Uzbekistan 2026; other states listed as prospective, not actual

G20 -> African Union a permanent member from 9 September 2023

Johannesburg Summit 22-23 November 2025; United States holds 2026 presidency

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 8/12: Minilateral against treaty alliance

QUAD -> India, Australia, Japan, United States; non-treaty consultative
Leaders' Summit: Wilmington, Delaware, 21 September 2024
Foreign Ministers: New Delhi, 26 May 2026 -> Indo-Pacific Maritime Security
Cooperation initiative; Indo-Pacific Energy Security initiative;
Critical Minerals Framework announced; Critical Minerals Initiative 1 July 2025
India announced as intended host; no held summit and no postponement verified

NATO -> North Atlantic Treaty signed 4 April 1949, Washington, D.C., 12 states
Belgium, Canada, Denmark, France, Iceland, Italy, Luxembourg, Netherlands,
Norway, Portugal, United Kingdom, United States; ratified within five months
Article 5 invoked once ever, after 11 September 2001; confirmed 2 October 2001
Finland joined 2023; Sweden the 32nd member, March 2024; Council by consensus

DECISIVE LINE -> collective defence is a treaty obligation; the Quad has none

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 9/12: How the alliance reaches India without India being in it

RUSSIA CHANNEL -> post-2022 consolidation deepens Russia-West confrontation

-> pressure on defence spares, energy, payments and diplomatic balancing

EUROPE CHANNEL -> Finland and Sweden expand northern geography

-> stronger United States-Europe coordination, but attention and defence industrial capacity can shift toward Europe

TECHNOLOGY CHANNEL -> tighter export-control and sanctions coordination

-> exposure for Indian firms and technology partnerships

INDIAN RESPONSE -> diversify defence supply; deepen India-EU and bilateral

European ties; keep issue-based Russia engagement; refuse alliance logic

RULE -> analyse transmission, not membership, when India is outside the body

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 10/12: Trilateral platforms and the subregional mechanism

IBSA -> India, Brazil, South Africa; Sikri: potentially significant

Leaders' Meeting, Johannesburg, 23 November 2025

digital innovation alliance and climate-resilient agriculture fund proposed

STATUS -> proposals, expressly not established institutions

RIC -> Russia, India, China; also named by Sikri

no officially verified meeting since the virtual 18th Foreign Ministers'

Meeting of 26 November 2021

MEKONG-GANGA -> 6 members: Cambodia, India, Lao PDR, Myanmar, Thailand, Viet Nam

most recent ministerial located officially: the 10th, Bangkok, 1 August 2019

corridor engineering routes to the neighbourhood owner

DISCIPLINE -> state the asymmetry whenever the platforms are listed together

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 11/12: Regime vocabulary that decides objective questions

MTCR -> India the 35th member, 27 June 2016

voluntary export-control arrangement; rule access, not guaranteed transfer

NSG -> India not a member; application distinct from the 2008 India-specific

waiver enabling civil nuclear commerce; admission needs consensus

AIIB -> India a founding member and the second-largest shareholder after China

finance access and a governance stake, never unilateral control

SCO -> India a full member since 2017; access without shared threat perception

IAEA ADDITIONAL PROTOCOL -> in force 25 July 2014; applies to safeguards only

it does not make India a non-nuclear-weapon State under the NPT

GAP -> ASEM joined 2007; APEC still a non-membership example, 3 August 2026

ASCII MASTER FLOW – PANEL 12/12: Answer spine for a groupings or minilateralism demand

OPEN -> name the layer, the legal form and the exact participation tier

EVIDENCE -> one dated instrument with its precise evidentiary level attached

COMPARE -> treaty-bound charter body against non-treaty coalition, both named

TEST -> separate announced, signed, in force and in force for how many members

CONCEDE -> bandwidth cost, effectiveness variance, coherence dilution

OWNERSHIP -> the 2020 Quad, 2021 and 2023 SCO, 2022 BIMSTEC-SAARC, 2022 I2U2

and 2023 alliance-expansion demands are the routed Mains questions

CLOSE -> form must match the problem; multiplying memberships without delivery

or status precision produces only diplomatic symbolism

EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Verify current membership and...